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Increasing wind 49/32 • Tomorrow: Breezy 48/31 **B22**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

SUNDAY, JANUARY 11, 2026 • \$6

Overseas actions pull focus from living costs

Trump's opening moves in midterm election year cloud affordability push

BY NATALIE ALLISON
AND CLEVE R. WOOTSON JR.

In the closing weeks of 2025, President Donald Trump gave a prime-time speech on affordability and launched a swing-state rally tour that his advisers said would show voters his focus on domestic concerns — a messaging push intended to ramp up at the start of the year.

But the president's first major act in the new year was a military operation in Venezuela that led to Trump saying on Jan. 3 that the United States will “run” the South American country indefinitely. In the following days, Trump issued threats of military action in Iran and Colombia, hinted at U.S. intervention in Mexico and renewed his interest in taking ownership of Greenland.

The result has been a muddled opening message of the midterm election year, with Trump making clear that he has no plans to back down from a growing list of foreign entanglements, while the White House tries to assure voters that the president is delivering on promises to make life more affordable.

Mindful of the looming midterm elections, White House officials, including Vice President JD Vance, have sought to cast the Venezuela mission as one that will ultimately improve U.S. security and domestic quality of life, arguing that the capture of President Nicolás Maduro will stem the flow of illegal drugs and Venezuelan criminals entering

SEE TRUMP ON A8

The Sunday Take: Calling Trump a “neocon” stretches the label. **A2**



SEBASTIEN SALOM-GOMIS/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Taking on the race of his life

Charlie Dalin stood on the bow of his boat, a light wind at his back, the Atlantic Ocean spread out in front of him.

He had just begun sailing's most difficult race, a grueling 24,000-mile solo journey around the world called the Vendée Globe. The competition, which takes place every four years, starts with about 40 professional sailors. Nearly half of them never finish. Many capsize. One was never found.

As the fleet glided away from the coast of France late last year, cameras zoomed in on Dalin. He was the favorite after finishing second in 2021, a narrow loss that still haunted him.

He redesigned his boat to be faster and more aerodynamic, and the

Charlie Dalin stood up to the challenge of the world's toughest sailing competition — while fighting cancer

BY KEVIN SIEFF

French skipper Charlie Dalin sails off the coast of Lorient, France, on April 22, 2024. A year before the Vendée Globe round-the-world sailing race, Dalin was diagnosed with gastrointestinal cancer.

41-year-old looked almost like an extension of the 60-foot vessel: tall and angular, as if any excess had been blown off by the wind.

But Dalin had kept a secret from his competitors, his fans and even his own team as he embarked on a voyage that would take several months. He was battling gastrointestinal cancer.

He had been diagnosed a year before when a scan revealed a 15-centimeter-long tumor on his small intestine. At first, he wondered if he would survive. Then he wondered if he could race.

To almost anyone else, the idea would seem unhinged. The Vendée Globe had knocked out sailors in peak physical condition. What might it do to someone who was fighting for his

SEE SAILING ON A12

Heavy scrutiny for ICE tactics

POSITION AT CAR'S FRONT IS CRITICIZED

Officer may have created needless risk, experts say

BY MARK BERMAN,
MARIA SACCHETTI,
DEREK HAWKINS
AND DAVID OVALLE

The fatal shooting of Renée Good in Minneapolis on Wednesday has prompted new scrutiny of the tactics and training for the thousands of U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers deployed across the country as part of the Trump administration's mass deportation effort.

Administration officials have defended the ICE officer who shot Good as she pulled away in her SUV, saying multiple videos of the incident show that he acted in self-defense. But several former law enforcement officials who reviewed the footage and spoke to The Washington Post faulted the officer's actions.

They said the officer — identified through court records as Jonathan Ross, an employee of the agency's Enforcement and Removal Operations division — placed himself at needless risk, escalated the situation and went against best law enforcement practices during the incident. Law enforcement officers should not position themselves in front of vehicles, and they need to try to de-escalate confrontations and must generally avoid shooting into moving vehicles, these officials said.

SEE ICE ON A10

ICE protests: Demonstrations take place across the nation. **A11**

Iran on edge as protests, government threats grow

BY YEGANEH TORBATI

ISTANBUL — Protests in Iran continued through Saturday despite threats from the country's supreme leader that he would expand the government's crackdown on demonstrators.

Though details remain scarce due to a severe communications blackout, videos shared by Persian-language news outlets based abroad, including BBC Persian and Radio Farda, on Friday and Saturday showed huge crowds in cities including Tehran, Mashhad and Yazd, chanting for an end to the Islamic Republic and praising

Iran's deposed monarchy. Some videos from Tehran showed buildings set on fire.

The internet monitoring group NetBlocks said Saturday that the internet shutdown had surpassed 48 hours, and Filterbaan, a digital rights group that focuses on Iran, said international phone calls were being blocked. Iranians in the diaspora reported being unable to reach loved ones inside the country.

The weekend gatherings were the latest development in a series of protests and strikes that began nearly two weeks ago with mer-

SEE IRAN ON A16

11 sanctioned oil tankers defy U.S. blockade, imagery shows

BY SAMUEL OAKFORD,
JOYCE SOHYUN LEE,
SUSANNAH GEORGE
AND AMAYA VERDE

At least 11 oil tankers under U.S. sanctions were spotted last week well beyond Venezuelan waters, according to satellite imagery analysis, having fled the maritime blockade that President Donald Trump imposed as part of the administration's pressure campaign against the government there.

Six of the tankers were in the

Caribbean Sea but had moved at least 70 miles from the Venezuelan coast; one of those ships was seized on Friday. Three others had traveled more than 450 miles into the Atlantic Ocean and, according to one analyst, were being distantly trailed by what appears to be a U.S. Navy ship.

SEE TANKERS ON A17

Prediction markets: A well-timed bet on Maduro draws scrutiny. **A14**

Prisoner releases: Families await return of political captives. **A15**

After fleeing the Taliban, they felt safe in America

But a shooting in D.C. has changed everything for Afghan refugees

BY ROBERT SAMUELS

MANHATTAN, KAN. — Inside a small beige room in a modest beige house, three Afghan refugees gathered around a long table where a lifelong Kansan had prepared for them a lesson about the Constitution.

“When the U.S. fought for freedom, they needed to create new rules,” she told them on a Monday evening in early December. “It starts with the phrase ‘We the People.’ Remember that. We the people.”

Rohina Safa, 28, scribbled notes as she learned about the power of citizenship, clinging to a hope that she and the others might one day gain it. Nearly four years ago, she and the two other Afghans at the table fled their homeland to escape persecution from the Taliban. When they set foot in America, lawmakers and veterans groups across the nation eagerly embraced them. The urge to help was so strong that here, in a small city in the center of the country, local veterans started a refugee resettlement agency dedicated to helping them find a new life in Kansas.

But over the past year, the women have had to navigate a different America, one in which the zeal for their presence has begun to fade. Under a new administration and



ARIN YOON/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Fatima Jaghoori, second from left, co-founded a resettlement agency in Manhattan, Kansas. It serves Afghan refugees including, from left, Fatima Farahmand, Rohina Safa and Sediqa Baqeri.

SPORTS

Sports fan with a case of wanderlust? We have just the ticket in '26. **B1**

BUSINESS

A smaller home can be a happier one, a climate columnist writes. **B9**



ARTS & STYLE

The hunt for a stolen Jackson Pollock — and clues to a family's pain.

NATION

For the first time in 25 years, California is 100 percent drought-free. **A4**



TRAVEL

Kazakhstan's surreal canyons of Mangystau rival U.S. national parks.

BOOK WORLD

The literary legend who made Dr. Seuss and Ayn Rand household names.

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